more inclusive democracy. As noted in chapter 2, the Founding Fathers committed enormous mistakes – such as endorsing slavery and denying women the vote – but they also provided the tools for their descendants to correct these mistakes. That was their greatest legacy.

THE TWENTIETH CENTURY: MASS DEMOCRACY, BUT ALSO MASS TOTALITARIANISM

Printed newspapers were just the first harbinger of the mass media age. During the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, a long list of new communication and transportation technologies – such as the telegraph, the telephone, television, radio, the train, the steamship and the aeroplane – supercharged the power of mass media.

When Demosthenes gave a public speech in Athens around 350 BCE, it was aimed primarily at the limited audience actually present in the Athenian agora. When John Quincy Adams gave his First Annual Message in 1825, his words spread at the pace of a horse. When Abraham Lincoln gave his Gettysburg Address on 19 November 1863, telegraphs, locomotives and steamships conveyed his words much faster throughout the Union and beyond. The very next day the *New York Times* had already reprinted the speech in full,[52] as had numerous other newspapers from the *Portland Daily Press* in Maine to the *Ottumwa Courier* in Iowa.[53]

As befitting a democracy with strong self-correcting mechanisms in place, the president's speech sparked a lively conversation rather than universal applause. Most newspapers lauded it, but some expressed their doubts. The *Chicago Times* wrote on 20 November that 'the cheek of every American must tingle with shame as he reads the silly, flat and dishwatery utterances' of President Lincoln.[54] The *Patriot & Union*, a local newspaper in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, also blasted 'the silly remarks of the President' and hoped that 'the veil of oblivion shall be dropped over them and that they shall be no more repeated or thought of'.[55] Though the country was in the midst of a civil war, journalists were free to publicly criticise – and even ridicule – the president.

Fast-forward a century, and things really picked up speed. For the first time in history, new technologies allowed masses of people, spread over vast swathes of territory, to connect *in real time*. In 1960, about seventy